

PERMAFROST

A SHORT FILM SCRIPT

FADE IN:

EXT. THE WALL - NIGHT

Snow to the horizon in every direction, blue-white under a sky with too many stars. A wall, thirty feet of scarred concrete and steel, cuts the frame in half, disappearing into the dark on both ends. Wind scours its surface in long white ribbons.

A watchtower stands alone against it, one light burning at the top.

SUPER: NORTHERN LINE, YEAR SEVEN OF THE FREEZE

INT. WATCHTOWER - CONTINUOUS

Cramped, hot with a single heater, cold everywhere the heater doesn't reach. KELLEN VASS (30s, government-issue coat, tired eyes) watches a bank of monitors: static, snow, more snow. He eats from a ration tin without looking at it.

A shape crosses one monitor. He sits forward.

EXT. THE WALL, NO MAN'S LAND - CONTINUOUS

Wide shot: the wall on one side, an endless white plain on the other, and in between, a single figure dragging a sled through snow to her knees. NOOR (30s, wrapped in scavenged layers, fierce and freezing) doesn't stop moving. Doesn't look up at the tower. She knows it's there.

INT. WATCHTOWER - CONTINUOUS

Kellen keys his radio. Stops. Doesn't transmit.

He watches her instead, the whole slow, brutal length of her crossing, hand hovering over the alarm switch like it might burn him.

EXT. THE WALL, BASE - LATER

Noor reaches the wall itself and stops, chest heaving, staring up at a structure with no visible door for a hundred miles in either direction. She sits, defeated, back against the concrete, and simply waits for the cold, or the light, whichever comes first.

A service hatch grinds open ten feet from her. Kellen, lit from behind, says nothing. Just holds it open.

INT. TOWER, LOWER LEVEL - CONTINUOUS

A cramped storage room, barely warmer than outside. Noor sits wrapped in a Ministry blanket, hands around a tin cup. Kellen watches her from the doorway like he's not sure he's allowed to be in his own building.

NOOR

You're supposed to shoot me. Or call it in.
Ministry's very clear about the order.

KELLEN

I know the order.

NOOR

So why am I drinking your coffee.

He doesn't answer. Looks instead at her sled, dragged in behind her, no supplies, no food. Just a small child's coat, folded, empty.

Noor follows his eyes. Says nothing. He understands anyway.

EXT. TOWER, ROOFTOP - LATER

Wide shot: the two of them, tiny, standing at the tower's edge above the wall, above the snow, above everything. The line of the border runs beneath them, absurd from this height, a thin dark scratch across a white planet that doesn't know it's divided.

KELLEN

There's a supply convoy at 0400. They radio ahead, thermal check, headcount. If you're still here...

NOOR

I know what happens if I'm still here.

A long silence between them, wind doing all the talking.

KELLEN

Where are you trying to get to.

NOOR

(looking north, not at him)

Somewhere that isn't a line on somebody's map.

INT. WATCHTOWER - 0350

Kellen sits at the monitor bank, hand on the alarm switch again. Behind him, the hatch to the lower level stands open. Empty blanket, folded neatly on the chair.

He looks at the switch a long moment. Then reaches past it, to the log terminal instead, and types a single line.

INSERT: MONITOR SCREEN, 0350 PATROL: NO ACTIVITY DETECTED. WALL SECURE.

EXT. THE WALL, NORTH SIDE - DAWN

Wide, wide shot. The plain beyond the wall, empty for miles, except one line of footprints, already softening under new snow, heading toward a horizon with no fence on it.

INT. WATCHTOWER

The tower stands small in the far corner of frame. A light in the top window. Watching. Not calling it in.

FADE OUT.

END.